> *opinions of people in this country, and most important not only with respect to the temporal interests of the government in India, but as indicating the most advantageous system for the gradual spread of Christianity in that large kingdom.* With regard to the policy of mercy which has been advocated this evening, I feel no distrust of Her Majesty's Government in that respect, and I am quite sure that there need be no fear of Lord Canning. It gives me great satisfaction to find the general concurrence which is now expressed by all in regard to that discrimination of punishment and to those principles of mercy for which the noble Lord made himself so very conspicuous last autumn, and then subjected himself to so much rebuke [emphasis added].

It is evident from this that the Christian hope that Christian freedom/toleration and Christian neutrality would gradually bring the idolatrous heathen from the darkness of his/her false religion into the light of the one true religion is a constant undercurrent that runs through each of the views. In light of all of this irrefutable material, it is my considered position that there is no reason to read and understand the Queen's Proclamation of 1 November 1858 as being any different in its intent and import from the views of the members of the British Parliament, including the then prime minister. It is in this context that the passing of the 1858 Act must be understood, instead of making the erroneous assumption that the administrative structure laid down by the Act was intended to address only issues of 'secular' governance. If anything, the word 'secular' must always be understood as 'Christian secular', since the Christian worldview was inherent to the colonial infrastructure. Therefore, the transfer of territories and government of British India to the Crown under the Act marked the beginning of a direct Christian 'civilising' phase for Bharat, which was partially held back until then due to the mercantile pragmatism of the Company. After all, the missionary clauses in the Charter Acts of 1813 and 1833 were not included at the behest of the Company, but were included at the behest of the British Parliament, which would thenceforth directly govern Bharat by virtue of the 1858 Act. In any case, perhaps, what most people do not pay attention to is the Preamble of these Acts, which inevitably contained the following portion: